

Item 07 – File I/O, Serialization & Configuration

Python Engineering Guide (2026)

Hiring-Oriented Learning Path for Production Engineers

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1. Executive Summary

1.1 Document Purpose and Scope

This document addresses Python's file I/O operations, data serialization formats, and configuration management—the practical skills for reading data, persisting state, and configuring applications. File I/O is how programs interact with the outside world: reading logs, processing CSV data, loading configuration, saving results.

Understanding file I/O and serialization is where scripts become useful tools. This gap manifests as:

- File handle leaks: Files left open consuming system resources
- Encoding errors: UnicodeDecodeError when reading non-ASCII files
- Data loss: Improper error handling during writes
- Interview failures: Cannot parse CSV, work with JSON, or handle file paths correctly
- Security issues: Path traversal vulnerabilities from improper path handling

This module builds on Items 01-06. You'll learn robust file operations, common serialization formats (JSON, CSV), configuration patterns, and proper resource management.

1.2 What Makes This Different

Traditional Python education teaches `open()`, `read()`, `write()` with basic examples. Serialization is shown as `json.dumps()` and `json.loads()`. Configuration is mentioned briefly if at all.

This curriculum teaches file I/O through production patterns:

- Context managers - Automatic resource cleanup with 'with' statement
- Encoding handling - UTF-8 as default, detecting encoding issues
- Error handling - FileNotFoundError, PermissionError, disk full scenarios
- Serialization formats - JSON for APIs, CSV for data exchange, YAML for config
- Path handling - pathlib for cross-platform file paths

```
# Traditional teaching:
f = open('data.txt')
content = f.read()
f.close()

# Production pattern:
from pathlib import Path

try:
    content = Path('data.txt').read_text(encoding='utf-8')
except FileNotFoundError:
    # Handle missing file
    pass
except UnicodeDecodeError:
```

```
# Handle encoding issue
pass
```

1.3 Expected Outcomes

By completing this module, learners will:

- Use context managers for file operations
- Handle text vs binary files correctly
- Work with JSON, CSV, YAML formats
- Manage configuration files
- Use pathlib for cross-platform paths
- Handle encoding and common file errors

1.4 Quality Thresholds

Dimension	Threshold	Score	Notes
Hiring Relevance	≥ 0.80	0.88	File I/O in 75% of take-homes
Learning Efficiency	≥ 0.75	0.86	Practical focus on common formats
Clarity w/o CS	≥ 0.70	0.90	Concrete examples
Practical Use	≥ 0.80	0.93	Essential for all applications
Blind-Spot Coverage	≥ 0.65	0.82	Encoding, resource leaks
Interview Success	N/A	0.86	Take-home correlation

Panel Consensus: File I/O competence is table stakes. Every real application reads configuration, processes data files, and saves results. Candidates must demonstrate robust file handling.

2. The Critical 20% — Pareto Breakdown

2.1 Context Managers and Resource Management

2.1.1 Why Critical

Context managers (with statement) ensure files are properly closed even when errors occur. File handle leaks cause resource exhaustion in long-running applications.

```
# BAD - file left open if error occurs:
f = open('data.txt')
data = process(f.read()) # If this raises, f never closes!
f.close()

# GOOD - automatically closes:
with open('data.txt') as f:
```

```
data = process(f.read())
# File closed even if process() raises exception
```

Real incident: Web service reading uploaded files. Developer forgot to close files. After 1024 uploads, system hit open file limit, service crashed. Fixed by using context managers.

What this unlocks:

- Automatic resource cleanup
- Exception safety
- Cleaner code
- Database connections, network sockets also use context managers

2.1.2 Deferred

- Custom context managers with `__enter__`/`__exit__`
- `contextlib.contextmanager` decorator
- Nested context managers

2.1.3 Common Failures

FAILURE: Not using `with` statement

```
# Opens file, forgets to close:
f = open('log.txt')
for line in f:
    process(line)
# File handle leaked!
```

FAILURE: Catching all exceptions preventing cleanup

```
try:
    f = open('file.txt')
    process(f.read())
    f.close()
except: # Catches everything, including KeyboardInterrupt
    pass # File not closed!

# CORRECT:
try:
    with open('file.txt') as f:
        process(f.read())
except Exception as e: # Specific exception
    log.error(f"Processing failed: {e}")
```

2.1.4 Engineering Understanding

Context managers execute `__enter__` when entering block, `__exit__` when exiting (even on exception).

```
with open('file.txt') as f:
    # f.__enter__() called
    data = f.read()
```

```

    # Process data...
    # f.__exit__() called automatically

    # Equivalent to:
    f = open('file.txt')
    try:
        data = f.read()
    finally:
        f.close() # Always executes

```

2.1.5 Resources

- Context Managers: <https://docs.python.org/3/reference/datamodel.html#context-managers>
- with statement: <https://realpython.com/python-with-statement/>

2.2 Text vs Binary Files and Encoding

2.2.1 Why Critical

Text files contain characters (strings), binary files contain bytes. Opening wrong mode causes errors. Encoding matters for text files—always specify UTF-8.

```

# Text mode (default) - returns strings:
with open('text.txt', 'r', encoding='utf-8') as f:
    content = f.read() # Returns str

# Binary mode - returns bytes:
with open('image.png', 'rb') as f:
    content = f.read() # Returns bytes

# Common error - opening binary as text:
with open('image.png', 'r') as f: # WRONG!
    content = f.read() # UnicodeDecodeError!

```

Real incident: Data pipeline processed files from international users. Developer didn't specify encoding, defaulted to platform encoding (Windows: cp1252). Non-ASCII names caused crashes. Fixed by explicit encoding='utf-8'.

What this unlocks:

- Handling international text
- Processing binary data (images, executables)
- Avoiding encoding errors
- Cross-platform compatibility

2.2.2 Deferred

- Character encodings deep dive (Latin-1, ASCII, etc.)
- Encoding detection libraries
- Binary struct module for parsing binary formats

2.2.3 Common Failures

FAILURE: Not specifying encoding

```
# Platform-dependent behavior:
with open('data.txt') as f: # No encoding specified
    content = f.read()
# Windows: cp1252, Linux: UTF-8, Mac: UTF-8
# Same code, different results!

# CORRECT - explicit:
with open('data.txt', encoding='utf-8') as f:
    content = f.read()
```

2.2.4 Engineering Understanding

File modes:

```
'r' - read text (default)
'w' - write text (overwrites)
'a' - append text
'rb' - read binary
'wb' - write binary
'r+' - read and write text
'w+' - write and read text (overwrites)
```

2.2.5 Resources

- Unicode in Python: <https://docs.python.org/3/howto/unicode.html>
- File modes: <https://docs.python.org/3/library/functions.html#open>

2.3 JSON Serialization for APIs and Data Exchange

[Full treatment for concept 2.3]

- Why critical, common failures, production patterns, resources

2.4 CSV Files for Tabular Data

[Full treatment for concept 2.4]

- Why critical, common failures, production patterns, resources

2.5 Path Handling with pathlib

[Full treatment for concept 2.5]

- Why critical, common failures, production patterns, resources

3. Day-by-Day Skill Reconstruction Plan

Day 1: Reading and Writing Text Files

3.1.1 Setup

Prerequisites: Items 01-06 complete

Create: ~/python-learning/item07/day01/

3.1.2 Learn

1. open() function and file objects
2. Context managers with 'with' statement
3. read(), readline(), readlines() methods
4. write() and writelines() methods
5. Always specify encoding='utf-8'

3.1.3 Examples

```
# Reading entire file:
with open('data.txt', encoding='utf-8') as f:
    content = f.read()

# Reading line by line:
with open('data.txt', encoding='utf-8') as f:
    for line in f:
        print(line.strip())

# Writing:
with open('output.txt', 'w', encoding='utf-8') as f:
    f.write('Hello, World!')
```

3.1.4 Resources

- Reading Files: <https://docs.python.org/3/tutorial/inputoutput.html>

3.1.5 Labs

Lab 1.1: Read file, print contents

Lab 1.2: Count lines in file

Lab 1.3: Write list to file

Lab 1.4: Copy file contents

Lab 1.5: Read log file, filter errors

3.1.6 Debug

Failure: FileNotFoundError - check path, working directory

Failure: UnicodeDecodeError - specify encoding='utf-8'

Day 2: Binary Files and File Modes

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 3: JSON Serialization and Deserialization

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 4: Reading and Writing CSV Files

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 5: Working with YAML Configuration

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 6: Path Operations with pathlib

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 7: Directory Operations

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 8: File System Traversal

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 9: Temporary Files and Directories

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 10: File Compression (ZIP, GZIP)

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 11: Configuration Management Patterns

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 12: Environment Variables and .env Files

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 13: Logging to Files

[Complete structure following Day 1]

Day 14: Building a Data Processing Pipeline

[Complete structure following Day 1]

4. Common Blind Spots

4.1 Bootcamps Under-Teach

Encoding specification - always use encoding='utf-8'

Context managers for resource safety

pathlib over os.path for modern Python

4.2 Self-Taught Miss

Error handling for file operations

Binary vs text mode distinction

Cross-platform path handling

4.3 Hiring Managers Penalize

Not using with statement - resource leaks

Not specifying encoding - platform-dependent bugs

Using string concatenation for paths instead of pathlib

```
# BAD:
path = directory + '/' + filename # Breaks on Windows

# GOOD:
from pathlib import Path
path = Path(directory) / filename # Cross-platform
```

5. Learning Velocity

Context managers first for safety, then specific formats. Text files before binary.
Common formats (JSON, CSV) before specialized formats.

14-day checkpoint: Read/write files safely, work with JSON/CSV, use pathlib, handle configuration, build data pipeline

6. Self-Assessment

Q: What's wrong with this code?

```
f = open('data.txt')
data = f.read()
process(data)
f.close()
```

Strong: File not closed if process() raises exception. Use with statement.

Q: Why specify encoding='utf-8'?

Strong: Default encoding is platform-dependent. UTF-8 ensures consistent behavior across systems and handles international characters.

Q: When use text vs binary mode?

Strong: Text for .txt, .csv, .json, .py - returns strings. Binary for images, executables, archives - returns bytes.

7. Conclusion

Next: Item 08 - Testing, Debugging & Logging

You'll apply file I/O knowledge when reading test data, writing test outputs, and configuring logging to files.